



D6 STORYTELLER

QUICKSTART

Everything a new table needs for a first session of D6 Storyteller, the fiction-first roleplaying system by Alex Merced. Players describe what they do, pick an approach, roll a handful of six-sided dice, and read the highest die. Print these pages, run session zero, and play.

IN THIS PACKET

- 1 Player Rules Cheat Sheet**
How a roll works, reading the dice, the four approaches, position and effect, assists, and conditions. Hand it to each player.
- 2 Storyteller Quick Reference**
Dice results, the position table with failure costs, effect levels, conditions and recovery, Ticking Clocks, and Storyteller principles.
- 3 Core Character Sheet**
Approaches, descriptors, Drive and Flaw, conditions, a setting mechanic box, and bonds. One per player.
- 4 Session Zero Worksheet**
Campaign basics, tone, safety tools, table expectations, character connections, and the opening question. Fill it in together.

The full rules, genre advice, and settings are in *D6 Storyteller: The Core Rulebook* and its companion books. More free printables, the dice roller, and 200+ free settings: d6storyteller.alexmerced.com
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HOW A ROLL WORKS

- 1 Describe what your character does and how they do it.
- 2 The Storyteller sets **Position** (how dangerous) and **Effect** (how much you can accomplish).
- 3 Pick the **Approach** that matches your action.
- 4 Gather your dice pool (approach rating, plus any bonuses).
- 5 Roll. Read the **single highest die**.

READING THE DICE

6 Full Success. You do it. No complications. Multiple 6s can mean even greater effect.

4-5 Partial Success. You succeed, but there is a cost, complication, or reduced effect.

1-3 Failure. The action fails and a consequence follows. The story moves forward.

THE FOUR APPROACHES

FORCE

Direct physical action, strength, endurance, intimidation through physicality

FINESSE

Precision, speed, stealth, dexterity, subtle physical action

MIND

Analysis, planning, knowledge, memory, perception, problem-solving

PRESENCE

Social influence, persuasion, deception, leadership, performance

Your approach rating (1d6 to 4d6) is how many dice you roll. Higher rating = more dice = better odds.

POSITION (SET BY THE STORYTELLER)

Position tells you what happens if you fail. It does not change your chance of success.

CONTROLLED You have the upper hand. Failure means a minor setback.

RISKY Standard stakes. Failure means real consequences.

DESPERATE You are cornered. Failure is severe.

EFFECT (SET BY THE STORYTELLER)

Effect tells you how much you accomplish on a success.

- **Great:** More than expected. Faster, bigger, lasting impact.
- **Standard:** You accomplish what you set out to do.
- **Limited:** Progress is real but partial. More work is needed.

ASSISTS

Another player character can help if they have a plausible reason. They add their relevant approach dice to your pool. On a Partial or Failure, **both characters share the consequence**.

CONDITIONS

Conditions are consequences that affect your character.

SHAKEN Rattled, distracted, or winded. Minor mechanical effect.

HURT Injured, compromised, or in pain. Meaningful mechanical effect.

OUT Unconscious, captured, or unable to act. Removed from the scene.

Recovery: Conditions improve through fiction (rest, medical attention, time). The Storyteller decides when recovery happens based on what makes narrative sense.

YOUR CHARACTER SHEET

- **Descriptors:** Short phrases describing who your character is.
- **Drive:** What pushes your character forward.
- **Flaw:** A weakness or complication that creates drama.
- **Bonds:** Connections to other characters and NPCs.



DICE RESULTS

6 Full Success. The character achieves the goal. Multiple 6s = *Great Effect* (more, faster, or lasting).

4-5 Partial Success. Success with a cost - a complication, partial outcome, or new threat introduced by the Storyteller.

1-3 Failure. The goal isn't achieved - and something worse follows. The story always continues.

APPROACHES (8 DICE TOTAL)

FORCE

Direct, physical, powerful action

FINESSE

Precise, quick, subtle action

MIND

Analysis, knowledge, planning

PRESENCE

Social influence, leadership

Minimum 1d6 in each approach.
Distribute remaining 4d6 based on character concept.

THE ROLL - STEP BY STEP

- 1. **Establish the fiction.** What is happening? What does the character attempt?
- 2. **Set Position.** Controlled / Risky / Desperate - determined by the fiction.
- 3. **Choose Approach.** Which approach is most relevant?
- 4. **Assemble pool.** Approach dice $\pm$ position adjustment $\pm$ assists.
- 5. **Roll.** Read the single highest die.
- 6. **Narrate outcome.** Shape of result from the roll; detail from the table.

POSITION

POSITION	SITUATION	FAILURE COST
CONTROLLED	Upper hand; limited downside	Minor setback or complication
RISKY	Standard stakes; real danger	Meaningful consequence, harm, or escalation
DESPERATE	Cornered; serious threat	Severe harm, major loss, or worst-case scenario

Position is set by the fiction before the roll. Even Desperate rolls can succeed - the position shapes the cost of failure, not the chance of success.

EFFECT

- Great Effect** - multiple 6s or exceptional advantage: more, faster, lasting impact.
- Standard Effect** - a single 6 under normal circumstances.
- Limited Effect** - success is real but partial or constrained (fiction, not the roll, determines this).

Effect is established before rolling alongside position. Ask: *"If they succeed, how much can they actually accomplish here?"*

ASSISTS

A second character may assist if they have a **credible, narratively plausible** way to help. They contribute their relevant approach dice to the pool. On a Partial Success or Failure, **both** characters share the consequence. No free assists.

CONDITIONS

- Minor** - narrative inconvenience only. No mechanical effect.
- Moderate** - lose 1 die from the most relevant approach.
- Severe** - position on related rolls worsens one step.
- Out** - character cannot act until treated.

Conditions are descriptive first. Name the condition specifically (*"Broken wrist," "Humiliated before the court"*).

RECOVERY

- Between scenes: roll **Mind** (self-treatment) or **Presence** (aided).
- 6 $\rightarrow$ clear one condition.
- 4-5 $\rightarrow$ clear one but a complication (supplies used, rest required).
- 1-3 $\rightarrow$ condition worsens one level.

STORYTELLER PRINCIPLES

- Follow the fiction. Let position and effect emerge from what's actually happening.
- Make failure interesting. Failure should complicate the story, not stop it.
- Partial success = success + twist. Don't just give them both.
- Telegraph danger. If Desperate, make sure the players know before they roll.
- Make NPCs want things. Every NPC should have a legible agenda.
- Escalate clocks visibly. Let players see what they're racing against.

TICKING CLOCK QUICK REFERENCE

Set a numbered countdown (3-8).
Advance one step when:

- A character fails a roll.
- A Desperate roll results in Partial Success.
- Players skip an opportunity to intervene.

When clock hits zero: the threatened event occurs.



D6 STORYTELLER

CHARACTER SHEET: CORE RULES ONLY

CORE RULES

✓ THIS SHEET COVERS THE CORE D6 STORYTELLER RULES ONLY. FOR OPTIONAL MECHANICS (WOUND CLOCK, MOMENTUM BANK, EMOTIONAL BURDEN, ETC.) USE THE

OPTIONAL
MECHANICS
ADD-ON
SHEETS

AVAILABLE AT
[D6STORYTELLER.ALEXMERCED.COM/DOWNLOADS/](https://d6storyteller.alexmerced.com/downloads/)

IDENTITY

CHARACTER NAME _____ SETTING _____ ARCHETYPE _____

PLAYER NAME _____ BOOK / COMPANION _____

APPROACHES

FORCE



Direct · Physical

FINESSE



Precise · Subtle

MIND



Analysis · Knowledge

PRESENCE



Social · Leadership

8 TOTAL DICE. MIN 1D6 EACH. FILL DOTS: ●●●○ = 3D6.
REMAINING 4D6 DISTRIBUTED FREELY.

DESCRIPTORS

3–5 vivid phrases that define who your character is

DRIVE & FLAW

DRIVE - WHAT I FUNDAMENTALLY WANT

FLAW - WHERE I RELIABLY GO WRONG

CONDITIONS

MINOR

NO MECHANICAL EFFECT

write name of condition

MODERATE

–1 DIE ON RELEVANT APPROACH

write name of condition

SEVERE

POSITION WORSENS ONE STEP

write name of condition

RECOVERY (BETWEEN SCENES): ROLL MIND (SELF) OR PRESENCE (AIDED) · 6 = CLEAR ONE CONDITION · 4–5 = CLEAR ONE + COMPLICATION
· 1–3 = WORSEN ONE LEVEL

SETTING-SPECIFIC MECHANIC

Fill in from your companion book

MECHANIC NAME

HOW IT WORKS

CURRENT VALUE / STATUS

BONDS, CONTACTS & DEBTS

NOTES & SESSION HIGHLIGHTS



USING OPTIONAL MECHANICS? THE D6 STORYTELLER OPTIONAL MECHANICS (WOUND CLOCK, MOMENTUM BANK, EMOTIONAL BURDEN, REPUTATION WEB, ETC.) ARE TRACKED ON SEPARATE ADD-ON SHEETS - KEEPING THIS CORE SHEET CLEAN AND FOCUSED. DOWNLOAD THE **OPTIONAL MECHANICS CHARACTER ADD-ON** AND **CLOCKS & TRACKS** SHEETS AT [D6STORYTELLER.ALEXMERCED.COM/DOWNLOADS/](https://d6storyteller.alexmerced.com/downloads/)

6: FULL SUCCESS

Goal achieved. Multiple 6s = Great Effect.

4-5: PARTIAL

Success with a cost or complication.

1-3: FAILURE

Goal fails + something worse follows.



SESSION ZERO WORKSHEET

COMPLETE BEFORE YOUR FIRST SESSION

D6 STORYTELLER V1

CAMPAIGN BASICS

CAMPAIGN NAME

STORYTELLER

SETTING / COMPANION BOOK

EXPECTED LENGTH

- ☐ One-shot
- ☐ Short arc (3-5 sessions)
- ☐ Full campaign (6+ sessions)
- ☐ Open-ended

TONE & GENRE

Mark where your campaign sits on each scale.

SERIOUS ← → LIGHTHEARTED

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GRITTY ← → CINEMATIC

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MYSTERY ← → ACTION

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POLITICAL ← → PERSONAL

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GENRE / TOUCHSTONES (FILMS, BOOKS, SHOWS)

SAFETY TOOLS

Agree on which safety tools your group will use.

- ☐ **Lines & Veils:** Lines are hard limits. Veils happen off-screen.
- ☐ **X-Card:** Anyone can tap the X to skip a scene, no questions asked.
- ☐ **Open Door:** Anyone can step away from the table at any time.
- ☐ **Stars & Wishes:** End each session with what you liked and what you want more of.

LINES (TOPICS COMPLETELY OFF THE TABLE)

VEILS (CAN HAPPEN, BUT OFF-SCREEN)

OPTIONAL MECHANICS IN USE

Only check the mechanics your group has agreed to use. All are opt-in.

PER-CHARACTER MECHANICS

- ☐ Wound Clock (physical harm tracker)
- ☐ Momentum Bank (bankable tokens)
- ☐ Emotional Burden (psychological stress)
- ☐ Reputation Web (faction standing)
- ☐ Legacy Move (once-per-arc defining moment)

TABLE-WIDE MECHANICS

- ☐ Ticking Clocks
- ☐ Escalating Stakes

OTHER OPTIONAL MECHANICS

TABLE EXPECTATIONS

- ☐ PvP (player vs. player conflict) is allowed
- ☐ Character death is possible
- ☐ Romance subplots are welcome
- ☐ Players can introduce world details
- ☐ Sessions will have a hard end time

SESSION FREQUENCY & DURATION

OTHER EXPECTATIONS OR HOUSE RULES

CHARACTER CONNECTIONS

Each pair of characters should have at least one connection.

CHARACTER A	CHARACTER B	CONNECTION
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OPENING QUESTION

What is the one question this campaign will answer?